

CoARA Action Plan – University of Antwerp

Research policy statement

The University of Antwerp's research policy for the coming years is aimed at creating a stimulating and innovative environment in which excellent research flourishes and societal impact is central. The university aims to be a dynamic and internationally respected research institution, with a clear focus on quality, integrity, sustainability and interdisciplinarity. Researchers are actively supported in their professional development, with a specific focus on career guidance, mentoring and attracting and retaining top talent, both nationally and internationally. Strategic investment in cutting-edge research infrastructure and optimising funding strategies - including space for non-competitive resources - strengthen the university's scientific potential. Interdisciplinary research and innovative approaches, such as the use of AI and open science, are actively promoted to address complex societal challenges. Furthermore, the university is strongly committed to increasing the visibility and valorisation of its research results through targeted communication, collaboration with external partners and participatory research. Through international networks such as [YERUN](#) (Young European Research Universities Network) and [YUFE](#) (Young Universities for the Future of Europe), cross-border cooperation is further developed. In this way, the policy contributes to a forward-looking, inclusive and socially embedded research practice.

In general, research evaluation is approached as a continuous learning process, in which feedback from and to researchers is central. In this way, the University of Antwerp aims to achieve a modern, supportive and strategically relevant evaluation practice that stimulates high-quality research while doing justice to the diversity of scientific contributions. The evaluation practice aligns with international principles, including the SCOPE Framework, the Hong Kong Principles for Researcher Assessment and the guidelines of CoARA (Coalition on Advancing Research Assessment).

The University of Antwerp and CoARA

UAntwerp signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA) 24.10.2022 after a presentation of and a discussion about the 10 commitments at the meeting of the University's Research Board on 19 October 2022.

UAntwerp takes part in the CoARA working groups 'Multilingualism and language biases in research assessment' and 'Evaluating Social Sciences and Humanities (SSH) research globally'. A joint Flemish inter-university CoARA working group proposal (all Flemish universities together with VLIR – i.e. the Flemish Interuniversity Council) on the topic of 'evaluation of research units and teams' was also submitted as a CoARA working group, but was not selected. Nonetheless, all partners agreed to continue the inter-university collaboration with regular meetings.

UAntwerp and the 10 commitments

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in research according to the needs and the nature of the research

As is:

The University of Antwerp's 2024–2028 research policy strongly emphasizes the recognition of diverse research outputs and roles, including societal impact, interdisciplinary collaboration, and partnerships in and beyond academia. It promotes a quality-focused approach that respects discipline-specific criteria, ensuring that different academic cultures are valued.

- Since 2008, UAntwerp has used a model for research evaluation of teams inspired by the Dutch SEP, allowing research teams to define their own performance indicators aligned with their mission.
- Internal funding mechanisms support projects of varying scales, fostering both innovation and continuity, and encouraging collaboration across disciplines and career stages. Evaluation procedures for these internal projects have evolved to include narrative and contextualized reporting, enabling a more holistic view of researchers' achievements.
- Recruitment for tenure track and tenured positions uses qualitative assessments with room for diverse contributions, atypical career paths and attention for societal and economic valorisation. The evaluation framework for tenure track professors explicitly prioritizes quality and contextual relevance over quantity. Goal-setting interviews of research staff further support personalized and discipline-sensitive career development.
- The university's repository accepts a wide range of outputs, including non-written formats like datasets, software, exhibitions, and artefacts, reflecting a broad understanding of scholarly contribution.

Objectives:

1. UAntwerp is working on a shift from summative team evaluations to a formative, discussion-based model embedded in larger research clusters, fostering inclusivity and reflection. This new approach prioritizes constructive dialogue and context-specific analysis, allowing space for all disciplines and research contributions with. The goal is to strengthen a healthy and supportive research ecosystem that values diverse career paths and outputs.
2. The internal research funding process will evolve by introducing seed funding based on external success and by promoting bold and innovative research ideas. This change aims to broaden resource distribution and empower more researchers to initiate pioneering projects. Collaboration across disciplines and career stages will be further encouraged through this new research funding model.
3. The university will review and potentially simplify its evaluation procedures for tenure track and tenured staff to ensure they remain efficient and effective. More transparency will be introduced through improved internal and external communication about research policies and assessment practices.
4. Publishing detailed information on the university website will help clarify how diversity is valued in recruitment and evaluation.

2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer-review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators

As is:

- Peer-review is implemented in all forms of research assessment at the university (teams evaluations, evaluation of project applications and during recruitment interviews and staff assessments). External and international peer reviewers are used as much as possible. These peer-review assessments are complemented with indicators that best suit the type of evaluation. There is never a metric-informed evaluation without a commission of experts in the discipline being present. For these indicators and metrics, UAntwerp makes use of a uniform electronic cv that is automatically updated with central database information on publications (all forms of publications, not only peer reviewed publications), non-written output (such as exhibitions, software, datasets, documentaries, etc.), acquired project funding, defended PhDs, economic valorisation (licences, spin-offs) and internationalisation (based on signed agreements). For information not captured by the universities databases, the professors can add information on other important indicators themselves (membership of commissions, editorial boards, science communication, clinical duties, advisory tasks, services to society, etc.). In addition - for several competitive internal calls - there is a possibility to add a more narrative based short CV, providing more insight into the researcher's achievements, skills and contributions relevant for the proposed research in a more descriptive, contextualized format.

Objectives:

1. UAntwerp is already meeting this commitment. Still, it remains important to continue to sensitise and inform researchers and reviewers on the correct use and interpretation of quantitative indicators, and the differences that exist in this regard between the different research disciplines. To support our panels, reviewers and experts, UAntwerp will develop guidelines about good research assessment practices and the role of metrics.

3. Abandon the inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular the inappropriate uses of journal impact factor (JIF) and h-index

As is:

- The central departments at UAntwerp involved in research assessment (i.e. RIVA-the Department of Research, Innovation & Valorisation Antwerp and the HR Department) are gradually moving away from the use of journal metrics and h-index in general and moving towards more qualitative and holistic frameworks with room for more tailored personal goals and behavioural competencies. However, journal- and publication based metrics still can play a part depending on the type of evaluation, but never as a stand-alone element and always as extra information for the peer reviewers.
- During meetings and discussions it is clear that the use of journal metrics and the h-index for evaluation still plays a part on a decentral level (faculties and departments).

Objectives:

1. Check in documents and policies at central level how much weight is still given to journal based metrics and consider a further phasing-out.

2. Develop central guidelines about good research assessment practices and the role of metrics at UAntwerp that can be consulted on a decentral level.
3. Where evaluation documents are already aligned with a more comprehensive evaluation, with less emphasis on metrics, this could be more clearly stated in the selection criteria in certain call texts.
4. Consider UAntwerp participation in DORA as a signatory.

4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment

As is:

- UAntwerp does not use rankings in assessment procedures. It does refer to rankings with regards to communication or marketing.

Objectives:

1. UAntwerp is aware of the shortcomings and subsequent undesirable effects of the use of rankings (and specifically the league tables). The University takes a critical stance towards rankings, will publish a message on its website, and will consider participation in the 'More than our rank' initiative.

5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to

As is:

- There are already experts available at the departments involved to work out and implement necessary changes (dedicated personnel in the Department of Research, Innovation and Valorisation Antwerp (RIVA), the HR Department, the Library & Archives Department, and dedicated members of staff at the deans' offices).
- The majority of these experts come together on a regular basis as the 'Research Expert Group' to discuss topics relating to research project management and administration.

Objectives:

1. The expert staff already available will keep on professionalising by going to/giving presentations during relevant conferences or participating in webinars, training initiatives, etc.

6. Review and develop criteria, tools and processes for research assessment

6.1 CRITERIA FOR UNITS AND INSTITUTIONS With the direct involvement of researchers across career stages and research organisations, review and develop criteria for assessing research units and research performing organisations, while promoting interoperability

6.2 CRITERIA FOR PROJECTS AND RESEARCHERS With the direct involvement of researchers across career stages, review and develop criteria, tools and processes for the assessment of research projects, research teams and researchers that are adapted to their context of application

As is:

- The University of Antwerp actively engages researchers in shaping its research evaluation systems across multiple levels. For research teams, the envisaged new formative evaluation model is being co-designed with faculty representatives and discussed in a Flemish interuniversity working group, ensuring broad input and alignment with team science principles.
- For internal research projects, the Bureau of the Research Board annually reviews calls and procedures, incorporating feedback from review panels and researchers. New calls are developed with direct input from concerned researchers, and all call texts are approved by a faculty-representative Research Board. Researchers are kept informed through internal communication channels and Q&A sessions.
- The evaluation framework for research professors was revised through extensive consultation with faculty representatives and the HR department. Research professors contributed by giving their input with regard to the previous evaluation scheme, which helped shape the criteria for personal development and performance. The new system promotes continuous feedback and two-way dialogue, focusing not only on outcomes but also on the process and working conditions.
- For other professors, the formal evaluation procedures have been abandoned. Evaluation is only required when applying for promotion, within a framework that balances research, education, academic service and leadership.
- For early-career researchers, PhD and postdoc regulations are tailored to disciplinary contexts and developed with input from supervisors and expert committees.

Objectives:

1. The envisaged new research evaluation system of teams should prioritize ecosystem health by working together with the researchers: interoperability is foreseen to be a logical outcome.
2. For internal projects, raising awareness about the new seed funding criteria and providing researchers with clear guidance and tools will be essential. Stakeholder feedback will be actively gathered to refine this funding model.
3. The evaluation framework for research professors will be reviewed after its initial five-year phase, incorporating insights from faculty representatives and professors themselves.

4. For PhD candidates, the university will address inconsistencies in how internal committees apply progress standards. Promoting transparency and consistent interpretation of regulations will help ensure fair treatment. These actions will strengthen trust, inclusivity, and the diversity of research careers and contributions.
5. Except for a limited number of situations (tenure track completion, promotion applications, or when things go wrong, for example), formal evaluation procedures at individual level are being replaced by a stronger focus on goal setting interviews and permanent feedback. This requires a cultural change that will benefit not only professors but also early career researchers and professional service staff. More leadership training (e.g. how to give feedback and how to have difficult conversations with successful outcomes), is required, as well as higher participation levels.

7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use

As is:

- The trajectory of Responsible Research Assessment (RRA) and the reasons for the new approach of research evaluation of teams were/are frequent topics on the agenda of the University's Research Board.
- The evaluation procedures for tenure track and tenured professors are written down in clear and transparent guidelines. They also have several goal-setting interviews during their trajectory where the guidelines and evaluation criteria are discussed.
- The University of Antwerp has invested in a range of training methods (toolbox, webinar, F2F training) to improve recruitment and selection practices. This includes a qualitative approach towards research assessment. This information is an integral part of different guidelines for each phase of the recruitment and selection process.

Objectives:

1. In light of the new research evaluation system of teams, more communication will follow via the usual channels (e.g. website, newsletter, guidelines on the system, information sessions). Other possible changes with regard to research assessment in the light of RRA will be communicated in the same way.
2. Continue to raise awareness amongst panel members on RRA (communication, guidelines, ...)
3. Create a webpage dedicated to RRA practices with tips & tricks.
4. For recruitment and selection we will invest in ongoing communication campaigns to bring the information closer to our academic staff, we aim to increase the uptake of training by collaborating even more with faculties and invest in team-based initiatives. We will develop an extra guideline to bring all the information together about a qualitative approach in recruitment and selection (cf. HR Strategy, action 1 recruitment and selection).

8. Exchange practices and experiences for mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition

As is:

- In the CoARA working groups in which UAntwerp is a member, knowledge exchange exists by default.
- UAntwerp takes on a leading role within the Flemish inter-university working group on the topic of evaluation of teams and team science. There are regular meetings during which ideas and new initiatives are discussed. The goal is to develop new insights and to exchange information on practices and experiences across the Flemish universities.
- Information exchange also exists on a more ad-hoc basis via conferences:
 - o Poster presentation on RRA at UAntwerp during the [27th STI conference](#) in Leiden in 2023
 - o Presentation on the new system of research evaluations of teams during the [20th conference of ISSI](#) in June 2025.
 - o Application for an oral presentation on the procedure of this new system submitted for the [EARMA Conference 2026](#) in Utrecht

Objectives:

1. Continued participation in the CoARA working groups, the inter-university working group and via publications and conferences.
2. UAntwerp recently applied to host the STIENID 2026 conference, with 'Indicators for Responsible Research Futures' as the main theme for this event.

9. Communicate on progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments

As is:

- UAntwerp's signing of the ARRA and participation in CoARA was communicated to all researchers via an editorial in the monthly newsletter of the Department of Research, Innovation and Valorisation Antwerp in December 2022.

Objectives:

1. Communicate on regular intervals about updates regarding the implementation of this Action Plan to the Research Board of the University.
2. Inform the internal UAntwerp community on progress made via the newsletter, information magazine 'Stroom', on the internal website and the external community through the external website.
3. UAntwerp will organise an institution-wide research day on Responsible Research Assessment (RRA) in order to further sensitise researchers on RRA and to share good practices.

10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

As is:

- For the evaluation of its research assessment practices, the latest insights and best practices from the international literature are always taken into account. All decisions on new approaches are evidence-informed.
- As one of the Flemish universities, UAntwerp is part of the interuniversity consortium ECOOM (Centre for Research & Development Monitoring), which mission is to develop a consistent system of Science, Technology, Innovation, Entrepreneurship and Economic indicators for the Flemish government. ECOOM is also involved in different studies on research on research, and consists of groups at each of the five Flemish universities. In Antwerp, the ECOOM-Biblio and ECOOM-Entrepreneurship groups interact closely with the Department of Research, Innovation and Valorisation Antwerp – the Department which organises and sets up research visitations and evaluations of research professors.
- Insights on the evaluation procedures and the introduction of new practices in the research visitations are communicated via conferences and publications.
- Other data on research performance is publicly available through repositories and research information systems.

Objectives:

1. Continued contribution to research on research through ECOOM, conferences, publications and evidence sharing in CoARA working groups (see above)
2. In accordance with the DORA practical guide on RRA, UAntwerp will explore ways to optimise the procedure with regard to the post-award phase of internal research grant selection (feedback mechanisms, decision-making processes, sharing of results).
3. UAntwerp highly values [Open Science](#) and will further investigate how to optimise its open research information streams.